

Best Practices for Writing Research Abstracts and Plain Language Summaries

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Introduction to Research Abstracts

Research abstracts serve as the gateway to scientific papers, functioning like movie trailers that determine whether readers will engage with the full manuscript. A well-written abstract must be a complete, standalone summary that answers what is new, what it adds to current literature, and what the future implications are. (6 sources)

A research abstract serves as the critical gateway between your research and its audience, functioning much like a movie trailer that determines whether people will consider reading the rest of your manuscript ([Shah, 2019](#)). The abstract represents far more than a simple summary—it is often the most widely read component of any scientific paper and frequently the only section that readers access ([Simon et al., 2020](#)) ([Aga et al., 2022](#)) ([Mensh et al., 2016](#)). This makes the abstract pivotal for editors scanning submissions for peer review, reviewers forming first impressions, and readers worldwide who may only have access to abstracts through electronic databases ([Cals et al., 2013](#)).

An effective abstract must answer three fundamental questions: "What is new in this study?", "What does it add to the current literature?", and "What are the future perspectives?" ([Aga et al., 2022](#)). The abstract should function as a complete, standalone document that tells the entire story of your research without requiring reference to the main paper ([Aga et al., 2022](#)) ([Cals et al., 2013](#)). Many readers will never access the complete article, making it essential that the purpose, methods, and outcomes are crystal clear within the abstract itself ([Hays et al., 2019](#)).

The abstract serves as a distillation of your paper's four major segments—introduction, methods, results, and discussion—with each component requiring careful balance and brevity ([Simon et al., 2020](#)). Word counts typically range from 70 to 300 words depending on journal requirements, and abstracts can be either structured with specific headings or presented as unstructured single paragraphs ([Aga et al., 2022](#)). Regardless of format, an effective abstract must provide well-balanced information covering background, aim, methods, results, discussion, and conclusion while maintaining the three Cs: context (the gap in literature), content (what was done), and conclusion (the single take-home message) ([Aga et al., 2022](#)) ([Mensh et al., 2016](#)).

Evidence

(Shah, 2019)

[HOW TO WRITE A RESEARCH ABSTRACT](#)

"An abstract is like a movie trailer. People will only consider reading the rest of the manuscript if they find your abstract interesting. It is an outline/brief summary of your paper and your whole project"

"Do not commence with "this paper...", "this report..." or similar. It is better to write about the research than about the paper. Do not explain the sections or parts of the paper. Avoid sentences that end in "...is described", "...is reported", "...is analyzed" or similar. Do not begin sentences with "it is suggested that...", "it is believed that...", "it is felt that..." or similar. In every case, the four words can be omitted without damaging the essential message. Do not repeat or rephrase the title. Do not refer in the abstract to information that is not in the document. If possible, avoid trade names, acronyms, abbreviations, or symbols. You would need to explain them, and that takes too much room. The abstract should be about the research, not about the act of writing."

(Simon et al., 2020)

Getting accepted – Successful writing for scientific publication: a Research Primer for low- and middle-income countries

"The abstract is an important part of the scientific article. After the title, it is next most often read and frequently the only part of the article read or available. The abstract is usually written last after all the basic components of the paper have been written.

The abstract is a distillation of the four major segments: introduction, methods, results, and discussion. Each of these segments should be brief. Make sure your objective is distinct from the background in your introduction. The purpose of the study should be encapsulated in one or two sentences and should contain a statement of the hypothesis. The methods paragraph should include only an outline of the procedures and variables and should detail the study design. The results should report only the principal findings of the study. The conclusion in the abstract should match the conclusion in the article. It is often easiest to write the abstract once the manuscript has been completed.

Review author instructions to see if it should be a single paragraph or have structured headings. Try to avoid using abbreviations or define them if you do use them. Do not cite references."

(Aga et al., 2022)

Essential Guide to Manuscript Writing for Academic Dummies: An Editor's Perspective

"(i) e abstract should essentially be written to answer the three main questions-"What is new in this study?" "What does it add to the current literature?" and "What are the future perspectives?" (ii) A well-written abstract is a pivotal part of every manuscript. For most readers, an abstract is the only part of the paper that is widely read, so it should be aimed to convey the entire message of the paper effectively (Mensh et al., 2016). (iii) Depending upon the journal, an abstract's word count can range from 70 to 300 words (Knight et al., 1996) and can be either structured or nonstructured in its presentation (Figure 4). (iv) An effective abstract is a rationalized summary of the whole study and essentially should contain well-balanced information about six things: background, aim, methods, results, discussion, and conclusion (Behzadi et al., 2021)(Cals et al., 2013). (v) A good abstract is succinct, easy to read, and independent in carrying the information. Care should be taken in providing the three Cs-context, content, and conclusion (C-C-C) (Figure 5) while writing it. Context provides the "gap in the literature," content covers the "what has been done in this study," and the conclusion provides the "single take-home message of the study" (Mensh et al., 2016). An effective abstract should be able to tell a complete story to the readers. (vi) An abstract should be written at the end, after finishing the writing of an entire manuscript to be able to stand-alone from the main text. It should reflect your study completely without any reference to the main paper (Cals et al., 2013). (vii) e authors need to limit/write their statements in each section to two or three sentences. However, it is better to focus on results and conclusions, as they are the main parts that interest the readers and should include key results and conclusions made thereof. (viii) Inclusion of excessive background information, citations, abbreviations, use of acronyms, lack of rationale/aim of the study, lack of meaningful data, and overstated conclusions make an abstract ineffective."

(Mensh et al., 2016)

Ten simple rules for structuring papers

"Good scientific writing is essential to career development and to the progress of science. A well-structured manuscript allows readers and reviewers to get excited about the subject matter, to understand and verify the paper's contributions, and to integrate these contributions into a broader context. However, many scientists struggle with producing high-quality manuscripts and typically get little training in paper writing. Focusing on how readers consume information, we present a set of 10 simple rules to help you get across the main idea of your paper. These rules are designed to make your paper more influential and the process of writing more efficient and pleasurable."

(Cals et al., 2013)

Effective writing and publishing scientific papers, part II: title and abstract.

"The title and abstract are the most important parts of a paper. They are important for editors who will scan the title and abstract to decide if it should be sent out for external peer review; for reviewers, who will get a first impression of the paper; and for readers, as the title, abstract, and keywords are often the only parts of the paper that are freely accessible to everyone online, including readers in developing countries. Electronic search databases use words in the title and abstract to yield search results. In PubMed, the similarity between documents is measured by the words they have in common, and terms in the title are given more weight. It is

therefore essential that the title and abstract contain all the important terms that potential readers may use in searching for relevant literature and "related articles." The author instructions of your chosen journal give information on requirements for titles. Some allow only single titles, whereas others allow subtitles, possibly with a colon. Informative titles are those that present the outcome of the study (e.g., *Drug x is effective in reducing cholesterol*), whereas some journals prefer a descriptive title stating the subject and design of the study (e.g., *Drug x for treatment of hypercholesterolemia: a placebocontrolled randomized trial*). Journals may require a short running title to be used at the top or bottom of each page, facilitating reader navigation through the journal. Journals usually require a structured abstract with headings (such as background, methods, results, and discussion). The abstract must clearly highlight the issue addressed by the study and the key findings. An abstract should be a standalone one, without any reference to the main text or the"

(Hays et al., 2019)

[How to review a paper on medical education](#)

"Abstract. Does the abstract summarise adequately the manuscript? Many readers will not read complete articles, so it is important that the purpose, methods and outcomes are clear. Structured abstracts make this easier for research papers."

Structure and Components of Abstracts

Abstracts follow a specific structural framework that includes rationale, methodology, findings, and implications, with each component requiring 1-3 sentences and the results/conclusions forming the bulk of the content. Writers should focus on telling a compelling story rather than just reporting study details, using clear transitions and avoiding unnecessary background information. (8 sources)

The structural foundation of an effective abstract follows a systematic framework that mirrors the main components of the research paper itself. Abstracts should be structured to include five key elements: rationale (1-2 sentences explaining why the research was needed), objective, methodology, findings, and implications ([Farley et al., 2024](#)) ([Novak, 2024](#)). This structure can be presented either as a single paragraph or with structured headings, depending on journal requirements ([Simon et al., 2020](#)).

Modern abstract writing emphasizes storytelling over mere study reporting. The results, analysis, discussion, and conclusion sections should form the bulk of your abstract, with writers advised not to hide their findings but instead compel readers through detailed results presentation ([Sims, 2023](#)). The discussion and conclusion serve as the "climax" of your story, connecting back to study significance rather than restating results ([Sims, 2023](#)).

Each structural component requires careful balance and brevity. Authors should limit statements in each section to two or three sentences, with particular focus on results and conclusions as these are the main parts that interest readers ([Aga et al., 2022](#)). The recommended distribution allocates one-third to background and problem statement, with the remaining two-thirds comprising objectives, contributions, and significance ([Piran et al., 2024](#)).

When constructing each section, specific guidelines apply. The methodology section should include only an outline of procedures and variables while detailing study design, avoiding excessive detail ([Simon et al., 2020](#)) ([Asghar et al., 2017](#)). The findings section must present specific data or general research results without making claims lacking proof ([Piran et al., 2024](#)). Technical contributions should clearly explain how approaches work and assert their performance relative to existing methods ([Piran et al., 2024](#)).

Language efficiency is crucial given the compressed nature of abstracts. Every word choice should be carefully considered, with ruthless editing of unnecessary adjectives and adverbs ([Sims, 2023](#)). Writers should use transitional words to show connections, avoid redundant phrases, write short sentences (maximum 20 words), and eliminate colloquial expressions ([Klimova, 2015](#)). Additionally, abstracts should avoid including tables, figures, references, excessive abbreviations, and overstated conclusions ([Aga et al., 2022](#)) ([Asghar et al., 2017](#)).

Evidence

(Farley et al., 2024)

Changing the paradigm for primary research dissemination

"Abstract should lay out five key points: Rationale (1-2 sentences) -why was the research needed? Objective"

(Novak, 2024)

The Editorial Word: Praxis

"Abstracts should be about 150 words (note that the APA guideline is 250, but the JoAA submission guideline is 150). A good rule of thumb is to write about 1-2 sentences on each of the following topics: essential points from the literature review that provide an introduction to the study; problem or research questions your manuscript will address; research hypothesis or hypotheses (if applicable, qualitative studies often do not have a hypothesis); brief description of research methods (e.g., design, sample); results; and implications (see link in References for a helpful guide; APA, 2020a)."

(Simon et al., 2020)

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The abstract is a distillation of the four major segments: introduction, methods, results, and discussion. Each of these segments should be brief. Make sure your objective is distinct from the background in your introduction. The purpose of the study should be encapsulated in one or two sentences and should contain a statement of the hypothesis. The methods paragraph should include only an outline of the procedures and variables and should detail the study design. The results should report only the principal findings of the study. The conclusion in the abstract should match the conclusion in the article. It is often easiest to write the abstract once the manuscript has been completed.

Review author instructions to see if it should be a single paragraph or have structured headings. Try to avoid using abbreviations or define them if you do use them. Do not cite references."

(Sims, 2023)

How to ... write an abstract

"The guidelines below will support abstract writing for submission acceptance, use and citation. 1 – 3 Lingard and Watling 's 4 ' It ' s a story , not a study ' provides a para-digmatic shift in thinking about academic writing. While a study lives in the methods and results of a report, a story unfolds in the introduction, discussion and conclusion. 5 A study may be primarily concerned with the accuracy of the reporting, but a story seeks to be persuasive – understandable, compelling and memorable. 5 To be persuasive, writers should focus on the how (organisation or structure of writing) and why (relevance and impact of writing, i.e., introduction, discussion and conclusion) questions, over the what (i.e., methods). 6"

"The results, analysis, discussion and conclusion sections should form the bulk of your abstract. 2,10Do not hide your findings! Compel the reader to continue reading your paper through including the details of your results, whether precise numeric data or complete qualitative themes. 2,9,10,14Providing incomplete or insufficient information in an abstract could lead to the rejection of your submission. 1"

"The discussion and conclusion are the 'climax' of your story. 15Do not restate your results; rather, connect back to the study significance in the introduction. This final section must state why this research matters, while highlighting the novelty and implications of the work. (Cook et al., 2016)4,15 explicit in reporting actionable conclusions: Do not make the readers guess at the meaning or impact of your findings. (Cook et al., 2016)For instance, 'take home messages' are often translations of findings into practice for the reader to implement. (Varpio et al., 2016)"

"The compressed nature of an abstract means that every single word choice should be carefully considered. (Varpio et al., 2016)Do not waste words on platitudes or filler sentences; ruthlessly edit unnecessary adjectives and adverbs. 4Use transitional words or phrases to show connections. (Varpio et al., 2016)"

(Aga et al., 2022)

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(Piran et al., 2024)

Enhancing Research Methodology and Academic Publishing: A Structured Framework for Quality and Integrity

"While preparing a manuscript, its Abstract is the last part to be written. They are concise summaries that convey the essence of a research paper after other sections are completed. A particular structure is followed, which starts with a background sentence explaining what the study aims to accomplish. It is followed by a statement outlining the study's purpose. Next, the study's objectives are clearly stated, followed by a discussion of its main contributions. Finally, the abstract concludes with a statement emphasizing the significance and merit of the research"

"Background, objectives, and contributions introduced in the abstract are aligned with corresponding sections throughout the paper to maintain clarity"

"Readers can quickly comprehend the paper's essence by understanding the research problem, methodology, key findings, and conclusions"

"Abstracts help readers assess a study's relevance to their interests without reading the entire paper"

"Abstracts are often the first thing potential reviewers and readers encounter, so clarity and precision are essential"

"Research findings, results, and conclusions must be summarized concisely in Abstract"

"Abstracts are expected to be a "stand-alone" version encapsulating the article's content and are usually between 150-300 words"

"Some journals require a graphical abstract for visual representation, normally a figure or diagram representing the main idea presented in the manuscript"

"Claims without proof are not expected in Abstracts, such as claims that the proposed model is simulated and compared with state-of-the-art methods, suggesting that all existing methods are inferior"

"An acceptable abstract is expected to contain one-third of the background and problem statement, with the remaining two-thirds comprising objectives, contributions, and significance"

"Technical contributions should be clearly stated, explaining how algorithms work and asserting their performance relative to existing methods"

"The ideal abstract must include background context, a problem statement, a clear objective, contributions articulated through proposals and discussions, and specific survey contributions, including problem statements and significance"

"It is important to articulate the advantages and significance of the proposed technique in terms of specific evaluation metrics to explain why it is superior to the related work"

"Justification should be given for the proposed work, along with its potential applications."

(Asghar et al., 2017)

HOW TO WRITE A SCIENTIFIC RESEARCH PAPER

"It is usually one paragraph summary of the entire paper. However, number of paragraph(s) should be according to the journal's instructions to the authors. An abstract should be self-explanatory without reference to the paper, but is not an alternate for the paper. The abstract should be no more than 250 words. Write abstract in passive voice and use active voice only when required. The first few sentences should state the background and objective of the experiment. The abstract must concisely explain the scientific question of the paper, materials and methods, results and conclusions. Do not include the detailed descriptions of materials and methods. Tables, figures or references, or references to literature cited usually are not a part of this section. The abstract is usually written after the write up of the whole manuscript. The abstract should be written in the following prescribed sequence: State the purpose of research unambiguously in the first or second sentence (from introduction) Describe the experimental design and methodology without going into the excessive details (from methods) Report those results that address the questions that were asked in the beginning (from results) Interpret the results and state the conclusion (from discussion) The final sentences should clearly mention the significance of the results. The abstract should contain approximately 3-4 key words."

(Klimova, 2015)

Teaching English Abstract Writing Effectively

"students should: prefer short words of Anglo-Saxon origin to long words of Latin origin (e.g. use to utilize); use the right collocations such low speed, high speed ...; avoid using colloquial words (so, stuff ...); not use the abbreviation etc. at all because it is not academic; always explain the acronyms first; always use informal style of writing; write short sentences (20 words at maximum); and avoid redundant phrases because the academic style is factual"

"the structure of an abstract which is usually divided into the following parts: Aim/goal of an abstract Methods used for the research or survey Findings/results Recommendations/implications for further research or survey"

Writing Style and Language Guidelines

Effective abstracts require simple, precise language with short sentences, active voice, and careful word choice that focuses on research findings rather than the writing process itself. Writers should avoid jargon, unnecessary abbreviations, and filler phrases while using transitional words to create clear, compelling narratives. (8 sources)

The language and style of scientific abstracts demand precision, clarity, and accessibility above all else. Writers should prioritize short words of Anglo-Saxon origin over lengthy Latin derivatives, use appropriate collocations, and construct sentences with a maximum of 20 words ([Klimova, 2015](#)). Language should remain simple throughout, employing active voice while avoiding jargon and technical terminology that might alienate readers ([Shankar, 2012](#)) ([Widodo et al., 2019](#)).

Word choice becomes critical given the compressed nature of abstracts, where every single word must be carefully considered ([Sims, 2023](#)). Authors should ruthlessly edit unnecessary adjectives and adverbs while avoiding platitudes or filler sentences ([Sims, 2023](#)). The writing must be accurate, brief, clear, and specific, using words that reflect precise meaning while maintaining honesty in presentation ([Widodo et al., 2019](#)).

Several specific writing practices should be avoided to maintain professional standards. Writers should not commence with phrases like "this paper," "this report," or similar constructions, instead focusing on the research itself rather than the act of writing ([Shah, 2019](#)). Sentences ending with "is described," "is reported," or "is analyzed" should be eliminated, as should opening phrases like "it is suggested that" or "it is believed that," where the qualifying words can typically be omitted without damaging the essential message ([Shah, 2019](#)).

Technical elements require special attention in abstract writing. Authors should avoid trade names, acronyms, abbreviations, and symbols when possible, as explaining them consumes valuable word count ([Shah, 2019](#)) ([Klimova, 2015](#)). When abbreviations are necessary, they must be explained upon first use, though excessive abbreviations can render an abstract ineffective ([Aga et al., 2022](#)). Citations should never appear in abstracts, which must function as standalone documents ([Widodo et al., 2019](#)).

To enhance readability and flow, writers should incorporate transitional words or phrases that demonstrate connections between ideas ([Sims, 2023](#)). The writing should maintain cohesiveness alongside other essential qualities including clarity, conciseness, organization, and self-containedness ([Wijaya et al., 2023](#)). Authors can improve their abstracts by applying revision strategies that increase reading ease scores, lower grade level requirements, and reduce passive voice usage while maintaining appropriate professional style ([Ford, 2018](#)).

Evidence

(Klimova, 2015)

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(Shankar, 2012)

What do reviewers look for in an original research article?

"The abstract is the section of the paper most commonly read and care should be taken while writing this section"

"Abstracts can be structured or unstructured, is usually written last and is often available freely through indexing services"

"Language should be simple, active voice should be used and jargon avoided."

(Widodo et al., 2019)

July 2019

"Abstract, which comprised of approximately 200 words, provides a brief description of research problems, aims, method used, results, and conclusion. An abstract should stand alone, means that no citation in the abstract. Consider it the advertisement of your article. The abstract should tell the prospective reader what you did and highlight the key findings. Avoid using technical jargon and uncommon abbreviations. You must be accurate, brief, clear and specific. Use words which reflect the precise meaning. The abstract should be precise and honest."

(Sims, 2023)

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(Wijaya et al., 2023)

A COMPARATIVE STUDY OF RHETORICAL STRUCTURE OF SEVERAL THESIS ABSTRACTS BY UNDERGRADUATE STUDENTS OF UNIVERSITAS BENGKULU

"An abstract should clarify the subject of your article, the issue your study is attempting to address or the question you are attempting to answer, how you went about doing this, and the conclusions you came to"

"Writing an abstract is a crucial step towards publishing your study, so put in the time and effort necessary to write a thorough, polished abstract"

"Background, purpose, method, outcome, and conclusion are common writing formats for the abstract's information. Additionally, the abstract should be no longer than one page and contain between 150 and 300 words. Additionally, the simple present, simple past, and present perfect tenses are frequently used in abstracts. Both the active voice and passive voice can be used to write those tenses"

"When creating an abstract, there are a lot of crucial considerations to make. Cohesion is one of the components. According to academic writing manuals and ESP instructors, cohesiveness is one of the abstract aspects that must be taken into account in addition to clarity, conciseness, organization, and self-containedness, according to Chan and Foo (2001). (p. 13)."

(Ford, 2018)

Abstract Analysis and Revision Assignment Using MS Word Readability Statistics

"improve upon these scores by applying revision strategies to rewrite the abstract, aiming to increase the reading ease score, lower the grade level score, and lower the percentage of passive voice while still maintaining appropriate professional style"

Content Guidelines and Best Practices

Effective abstracts should focus on storytelling rather than study reporting, with two-thirds of content devoted to findings and implications rather than background. Writers must include specific results, avoid unsupported claims, and ensure the abstract answers what's new, what it adds to literature, and future implications. (8 sources)

The content of an effective abstract requires a strategic shift from traditional study reporting to compelling storytelling. Modern abstract writing emphasizes that "it's a story, not a study," where writers should focus on the introduction, discussion, and conclusion rather than dwelling primarily on methods (Sims, 2023). The results, analysis, discussion, and conclusion sections should form the bulk of your abstract, with authors advised not to hide their findings but instead compel readers through detailed results presentation (Sims, 2023).

Content distribution should follow specific proportions to maximize impact. An acceptable abstract should contain one-third background and problem statement, with the remaining two-thirds comprising objectives, contributions, and significance (Piran et al., 2024). Authors need to limit statements in each section to two or three sentences, focusing particularly on results and conclusions as these are the main parts that interest readers (Aga et al., 2022).

The abstract must answer three fundamental content questions to be effective: "What is new in this study?", "What does it add to the current literature?", and "What are the future perspectives?" (Aga et al., 2022). Additionally, abstracts should address five key elements: what you have done, how you did it, what you found

that is new, why it is interesting, and what the ramifications are ([Schatz et al., 2022](#)).

Specific content requirements vary by section but follow clear guidelines. The methods paragraph should include only an outline of procedures and variables while detailing study design ([Simon et al., 2020](#)). Results should report only the principal findings of the study with specific data rather than vague statements ([Simon et al., 2020](#)). Technical contributions should clearly explain how approaches work and assert their performance relative to existing methods ([Piran et al., 2024](#)).

The discussion and conclusion serve as the "climax" of your story and should not merely restate results but connect back to study significance ([Sims, 2023](#)). Authors must be explicit in reporting actionable conclusions without making readers guess at the meaning or impact of findings ([Sims, 2023](#)). The abstract should conclude with a perfect sentence that summarizes your unique argument so readers have no choice but to see the importance of your work ([Dobbins et al., 2024](#)) ([Dupree et al., 2023](#)).

Critical content pitfalls must be avoided to maintain credibility. Claims without proof should never appear in abstracts, such as unsupported assertions about superior performance compared to existing methods ([Piran et al., 2024](#)). Authors should avoid excessive background information, citations, abbreviations, acronyms, lack of meaningful data, and overstated conclusions ([Aga et al., 2022](#)). The abstract must not refer to information not contained in the document and should avoid explaining sections or parts of the paper ([Shah, 2019](#)).

Evidence

(Sims, 2023)

[How to ... write an abstract](#)

"The guidelines below will support abstract writing for submission acceptance, use and citation. 1 – 3 Lingard and Watling 's 4 ' It ' s a story , not a study ' provides a para-digmatic shift in thinking about academic writing. While a study lives in the methods and results of a report, a story unfolds in the introduction, discussion and conclusion. 5 A study may be primarily concerned with the accuracy of the reporting, but a story seeks to be persuasive – understandable, compelling and memorable. 5 To be persuasive, writers should focus on the how (organisation or structure of writing) and why (relevance and impact of writing, i.e., introduction, discussion and conclusion) questions, over the what (i.e., methods). 6"

"The results, analysis, discussion and conclusion sections should form the bulk of your abstract. 2,10Do not hide your findings! Compel the reader to continue reading your paper through including the details of your results, whether precise numeric data or complete qualitative themes. 2,9,10,14Providing incomplete or insufficient information in an abstract could lead to the rejection of your submission. 1"

"The discussion and conclusion are the 'climax' of your story. 15Do not restate your results; rather, connect back to the study significance in the introduction. This final section must state why this research matters, while highlighting the novelty and implications of the work. (Cook et al., 2016)4,15 explicit in reporting actionable conclusions: Do not make the readers guess at the meaning or impact of your findings. (Cook et al., 2016)For instance, 'take home messages' are often translations of findings into practice for the reader to implement. (Varpio et al., 2016)"

"The compressed nature of an abstract means that every single word choice should be carefully considered. (Varpio et al., 2016)Do not waste words on platitudes or filler sentences; ruthlessly edit unnecessary adjectives and adverbs. 4Use transitional words or phrases to show connections. (Varpio et al., 2016)"

(Piran et al., 2024)

[Enhancing Research Methodology and Academic Publishing: A Structured Framework for Quality and Integrity](#)

"While preparing a manuscript, its Abstract is the last part to be written. They are concise summaries that convey the essence of a research paper after other sections are completed. A particular structure is followed, which starts with a background sentence explaining what the study aims to accomplish. It is followed by a statement outlining the study's purpose. Next, the study's objectives are clearly stated, followed by a discussion of its main contributions. Finally, the abstract concludes with a statement emphasizing the significance and merit of the research"

"Background, objectives, and contributions introduced in the abstract are aligned with corresponding sections throughout the paper to maintain clarity"

"Readers can quickly comprehend the paper's essence by understanding the research problem, methodology, key findings, and

conclusions"

"Abstracts help readers assess a study's relevance to their interests without reading the entire paper"

"Abstracts are often the first thing potential reviewers and readers encounter, so clarity and precision are essential"

"Research findings, results, and conclusions must be summarized concisely in Abstract"

"Abstracts are expected to be a "stand-alone" version encapsulating the article's content and are usually between 150-300 words"

"Some journals require a graphical abstract for visual representation, normally a figure or diagram representing the main idea presented in the manuscript"

"Claims without proof are not expected in Abstracts, such as claims that the proposed model is simulated and compared with state-of-the-art methods, suggesting that all existing methods are inferior"

"An acceptable abstract is expected to contain one-third of the background and problem statement, with the remaining two-thirds comprising objectives, contributions, and significance"

"Technical contributions should be clearly stated, explaining how algorithms work and asserting their performance relative to existing methods"

"The ideal abstract must include background context, a problem statement, a clear objective, contributions articulated through proposals and discussions, and specific survey contributions, including problem statements and significance"

"It is important to articulate the advantages and significance of the proposed technique in terms of specific evaluation metrics to explain why it is superior to the related work"

"Justification should be given for the proposed work, along with its potential applications."

(Aga et al., 2022)

Essential Guide to Manuscript Writing for Academic Dummies: An Editor's Perspective

"(i) The abstract should essentially be written to answer the three main questions-"What is new in this study?" "What does it add to the current literature?" and "What are the future perspectives?" (ii) A well-written abstract is a pivotal part of every manuscript. For most readers, an abstract is the only part of the paper that is widely read, so it should be aimed to convey the entire message of the paper effectively (Mensh et al., 2016). (iii) Depending upon the journal, an abstract's word count can range from 70 to 300 words (Knight et al., 1996) and can be either structured or nonstructured in its presentation (Figure 4). (iv) An effective abstract is a rationalized summary of the whole study and essentially should contain well-balanced information about six things: background, aim, methods, results, discussion, and conclusion (Behzadi et al., 2021)(Cals et al., 2013). (v) A good abstract is succinct, easy to read, and independent in carrying the information. Care should be taken in providing the three Cs-context, content, and conclusion (C-C-C) (Figure 5) while writing it. Context provides the "gap in the literature," content covers the "what has been done in this study," and the conclusion provides the "single take-home message of the study" (Mensh et al., 2016). An effective abstract should be able to tell a complete story to the readers. (vi) An abstract should be written at the end, after finishing the writing of an entire manuscript to be able to stand-alone from the main text. It should reflect your study completely without any reference to the main paper (Cals et al., 2013). (vii) The authors need to limit/write their statements in each section to two or three sentences. However, it is better to focus on results and conclusions, as they are the main parts that interest the readers and should include key results and conclusions made thereof. (viii) Inclusion of excessive background information, citations, abbreviations, use of acronyms, lack of rationale/aim of the study, lack of meaningful data, and overstated conclusions make an abstract ineffective."

(Schatz et al., 2022)

Advancing Access to Cutting-Edge Tabletop Science

"Participants receive suggestions about writing their abstract: (a) What have you done? (b) How did you do it? (c) What did you find that is new? (d) Why is it interesting? (e) What are the ramifications? The importance of succinctness and avoiding jargon is emphasized. The goal is to develop an abstract that will lead researchers who discover the paper to download and read it, rather than to move on to the next one in their literature search."

(Simon et al., 2020)

Getting accepted – Successful writing for scientific publication: a Research Primer for low- and middle-income countries

"The abstract is an important part of the scientific article. After the title, it is next most often read and frequently the only part of the article read or available. The abstract is usually written last after all the basic components of the paper have been written."

The abstract is a distillation of the four major segments: introduction, methods, results, and discussion. Each of these segments should be brief. Make sure your objective is distinct from the background in your introduction. The purpose of the study should be

encapsulated in one or two sentences and should contain a statement of the hypothesis. The methods paragraph should include only an outline of the procedures and variables and should detail the study design. The results should report only the principal findings of the study. The conclusion in the abstract should match the conclusion in the article. It is often easiest to write the abstract once the manuscript has been completed.

Review author instructions to see if it should be a single paragraph or have structured headings. Try to avoid using abbreviations or define them if you do use them. Do not cite references."

(Dobbins et al., 2024)

Editorial: Making Unstructured Abstracts More Concrete

"complete the abstract with a perfect sentence; one that summarises your unique argument in one sentence, so the reader has no choice but to see the importance of your work (Dupree et al., 2023)"

"An unstructured abstract must initially articulate the problem and then clearly summarise the research context. Key literatures used should be outlined, along with methods, findings and key implications of the research for practice for an international audience."

(Dupree et al., 2023)

Research and scholarly methods: Writing abstracts

"An abstract is a concise summary of scholarly work and is the first impression for the editor, peer reviewer, or journal audience. When presenting or writing up scholarly activity, an abstract is required for submission and guidelines vary depending on the conference, journal, and grant application. Many early career researchers and pharmacists feel unequipped to summarize research activity and need guidance to get started with abstract writing. A stepwise approach can be a valuable tool for all types of learners. From start to finish, this paper provides guidance and specific examples to write a high-quality abstract effectively for conferences, journals, and grant application submissions. By following the eight sequential steps of abstract writing provided, pharmacists can potentially develop a skillset to advance scholarly work and showcase it to the scientific community."

(Shah, 2019)

HOW TO WRITE A RESEARCH ABSTRACT

"An abstract is like a movie trailer. People will only consider reading the rest of the manuscript if they find your abstract interesting. It is an outline/brief summary of your paper and your whole project"

"Do not commence with "this paper...", "this report..." or similar. It is better to write about the research than about the paper. Do not explain the sections or parts of the paper. Avoid sentences that end in "...is described", "...is reported", "...is analyzed" or similar. Do not begin sentences with "it is suggested that..." "it is believed that...", "it is felt that..." or similar. In every case, the four words can be omitted without damaging the essential message. Do not repeat or rephrase the title. Do not refer in the abstract to information that is not in the document. If possible, avoid trade names, acronyms, abbreviations, or symbols. You would need to explain them, and that takes too much room. The abstract should be about the research, not about the act of writing."

Plain Language Summary Principles

Plain language summaries are jargon-free versions of research abstracts designed for non-expert audiences, using simple language, visual elements, and multiple formats including written, audio, and video versions. These summaries should follow structured approaches like the 1:3:25 rule, where information is presented in increasingly detailed formats to accommodate different reader needs. (5 sources)

Plain language summaries represent a fundamental shift from traditional scientific abstracts toward accessible communication designed for broad, non-expert audiences. These summaries are short, jargon-free versions of scientific publications that facilitate research accessibility beyond the academic community (Jackson et al., 2025) (Edgell et al., 2022). Unlike traditional abstracts that target scholarly readers, plain language summaries serve as bridges between complex research findings and the general public who may be directly affected by the research outcomes.

The format and presentation of plain language summaries can take varied forms beyond traditional written text, including graphical formats such as infographics and video presentations (Jackson et al., 2025) (Gasparini et al., 2024). Video abstracts should be kept to no more than 5 minutes in length to maintain audience engagement (Jackson et al., 2025). These multiple format options recognize that different audiences may prefer different ways of consuming research information.

Structured approaches provide frameworks for creating effective plain language summaries. The Open Accessible Summaries in Language Studies (OASIS) initiative offers one example of systematic guidelines for researchers to produce concise, one-page summaries of their work ([Jackson et al., 2025](#)). A practical formatting approach suggests the 1:3:25 rule, where evidence is presented in one page, three page, and 25 page formats, providing decision-makers with increasing amounts of detail ([Phipps, 2012](#)). This compressed approach can include a one sentence headline and a two to three sentence abstract highlighting the most important points, allowing readers to easily obtain increasing amounts of information as needed.

Language and readability remain central to effective plain language summaries. Writers should apply revision strategies that increase reading ease scores, lower grade level requirements, and reduce passive voice usage while maintaining appropriate professional style ([Ford, 2018](#)). The summaries should use strengths-based language and incorporate visual elements to enhance understanding ([Jackson et al., 2025](#)) ([Gasparini et al., 2024](#)). Authors are encouraged to seek feedback from non-expert audiences and share their summaries through social media platforms to maximize reach and impact.

Evidence

([Jackson et al., 2025](#))

[Making Research Accessible to the Developmental Language Disorder Community: A Mixed Methods Study Using the Nominal Group Technique](#)

"Plain language summaries are short, jargon-free summaries of scientific publications designed to facilitate accessibility of research by a broad, 'non-expert' audience (Edgell et al., 2022)"

"summaries may take varied forms, including written, graphical (e.g., infographics), or videos (Gasparini et al., 2024)"

"One example of existing guidelines for creating plain language summaries is the Open Accessible Summaries in Language Studies (OASIS) initiative (Marsden et al. 2018). OASIS offers a structured approach for researchers to produce concise, one-page summaries of their work on language learning, use, and education"

"There exist guidelines for creating other dissemination outputs, such as visual (Ibrahim 2018) and video (King et al., 2022)) abstracts, which focus on making research communication more effective for both academic audiences and the public"

"Hinckley and El-Khoury (2023) compiled guidelines for publishing 'aphasia-friendly' research, which included easy-read summaries, graphical abstracts, and video abstracts no more than 5 min long."

([Edgell et al., 2022](#))

[Putting plain language summaries into perspective](#)

"Abstract Publication-associated plain language summaries are brief, jargon-free summaries of scientific publications. They are intended for a broad, non-expert audience to help maximize the accessibility of the publication. Plain language summaries are typically found alongside peer-reviewed publications or in supplementary materials and can be indexed in PubMed. In this narrative commentary, we present the perspectives of five day-to-day users of plain language summaries from different stakeholder groups, gained through semi-structured qualitative interviews about the users' experiences with and opinions of plain language summaries. PLAIN LANGUAGE SUMMARY Plain language summaries such as this one are an increasingly popular tool for helping readers cut through jargon and understand the key points of a research article faster. To get a better idea of how plain language summaries are being used, we spoke to five people from different backgrounds who read, write and review plain language summaries in their personal and professional lives."

([Gasparini et al., 2024](#))

[How to create accessible research summaries for the developmental language disorder community.](#)

"BACKGROUND

Eighty-five percent of medical research goes to waste, partly because it is not appropriately communicated to stakeholders. This represents a critical issue for the research community, especially because individuals who are impacted by research should be able to readily access that research. Making research findings accessible to key stakeholders is an important step in implementation science and in enabling research to have meaningful impacts. Plain language summaries are a tool to make research more accessible to individuals with communication disorders. While guidelines exist to support researchers to develop plain language summaries for some populations, no such guidelines exist for the developmental language disorder (DLD) community.

AIMS

We aimed to develop evidence-informed guidelines to support researchers to create plain language summaries that are accessible for individuals with DLD, their families, and the broader community. This discussion paper describes the development of these guidelines and how they may be implemented by researchers who conduct research on the topic of DLD.

METHODS

We drew from existing plain language summary guidelines for other populations and knowledge of various barriers that may impact the DLD community's ability to access scientific research. We used this knowledge to create guidelines for researchers to develop plain language summaries of their research relating to the DLD population. This includes guidelines for creating written, visual, audio and video summaries. We consulted with an adult with DLD, an implementation scientist, and a speech-language pathologist regarding the suitability of the guidelines.

MAIN CONTRIBUTION

The plain language summary guidelines are publicly available via <https://osf.io/ydkw9>. They include templates and examples, as well as suggestions for writing and visual styles. We encourage strengths-based language, seeking feedback from non-experts, and sharing the summaries on social media. We have also developed an online repository for researchers to disseminate their plain language summaries via DLD advocacy groups.

CONCLUSIONS

The written, audio and video plain language summaries that researchers create using our guidelines can be used to disseminate research to the DLD community. This can facilitate science implementation and maximise the impact of DLD research. The plain language summaries may also help individuals with DLD better understand the research that has been conducted about them. This may in turn support their engagement with services and empower them to make evidence-informed choices for themselves and partner in co-designing new research. Future research could explore the perspectives of the DLD community and researchers regarding the implementation of these guidelines.

PLAIN LANGUAGE SUMMARY

A lot of research goes to waste. This is partly because researchers rarely share their results with the non-scientific community. People with communication disorders might find it hard to understand research papers. We made guidelines to help researchers explain their research to people with developmental language disorder (DLD). We brought together existing advice on how to explain research in a clear way. We sought advice from people with different experiences and perspectives, including an adult with DLD. The guidelines are at <https://osf.io/ydkw9>. The guidelines include advice on how to add pictures to research summaries. We also explain how to make a video or podcast summarising research. We encourage researchers to share their research summaries on social media. This means their research can reach more people and can make a difference. It is important that people with DLD understand DLD research. This might help them to understand their diagnosis and take part in future research.

WHAT THIS PAPER ADDS

What is already known on the subject For research to make a difference, it must be appropriately communicated to its stakeholders; however, only 1.5% of academic journals require authors to write plain language summaries. What this paper adds to existing knowledge This paper presents publicly available guidelines for researchers to create written, visual, audio and video plain language summaries aimed to be accessible for individuals with developmental language disorder (DLD) and their families. What are the potential or actual clinical implications of this work? Researchers can use plain language summaries to disseminate research to the wider community. This can help individuals with DLD better understand the research that has been conducted about them and may empower them to meaningfully partner in co-designing new research."

(Phipps, 2012)

A Field Note Describing the Development and Dissemination of Clear Language Research Summaries for University-Based Knowledge Mobilization

"The most desirable elements in the existing research summaries that corresponded to clear language writing and design were identified and synthesized by the Steering Committee to produce a template for the ResearchSnapshot series that contained the following elements:"

"propose a 1:3:25 rule where evidence is presented in one page, three page, and 25 page formats, providing decision-makers with increasing amounts of detail. In a more compressed approach, the Steering Committee recommended each two page ResearchSnapshot use a one sentence headline and a two to three sentence abstract of the summary (contained in the "What you need to know" box on the front page) to highlight the most salient points made in the summary. This format allows the reader to easily obtain increasing amounts of information from the research summary. Each ResearchSnapshot also includes the key words identified in the publication, as well as the citation of the original paper or academic report."

(Ford, 2018)

Abstract Analysis and Revision Assignment Using MS Word Readability Statistics

"improve upon these scores by applying revision strategies to rewrite the abstract, aiming to increase the reading ease score, lower the grade level score, and lower the percentage of passive voice while still maintaining appropriate professional style"

Quality Assurance and Revision

Writing effective abstracts requires extensive revision and takes considerably longer than expected, with successful abstracts needing feedback from colleagues who haven't read the full manuscript. Quality assurance involves checking for completeness, clarity, proper formatting, and ensuring key findings and implications are clearly stated. (5 sources)

Abstract writing is not a simple matter and can take considerably longer than anticipated, requiring continual revision and editing to achieve clarity and completeness ([Goyal et al., 2022](#)). The revision process demands careful attention to ensuring abstracts provide complete but concise descriptions of studies while incorporating keywords for indexing and database searches ([English, 2019](#)).

A systematic approach to quality assurance involves several key strategies. It is good practice to ask a colleague who has not read the full manuscript to read the abstract and provide feedback on its completeness and comprehensibility ([Goyal et al., 2022](#)). This external review helps identify gaps in clarity that authors may miss due to their close familiarity with the research.

During revision, authors should focus on specific content elements to ensure effectiveness. Abstracts should clearly state 1-2 key findings, 1-2 central assertions about how or why the findings occurred, and 1-2 conclusions or implications about what these findings mean for scholarship and practice ([English, 2019](#)). This focused approach prevents abstracts from omitting important details that would make it difficult for readers to judge the research as worth reading.

Technical quality assurance requires attention to formatting and structural consistency. Authors should adhere to specific journal formatting guidelines, which typically require 200-250 words though different journals have different formats ([Sulistiyo et al., 2021](#)). Researchers can enhance abstract quality by summarizing complex research effectively, balancing brevity and clarity, selecting relevant information, avoiding technical jargon, identifying key takeaways, avoiding ambiguity, and condensing content appropriately ([William, 2024](#)).

The broader academic community recognizes the need for systematic improvement in abstract quality. Key recommendations for enhancing abstract writing include greater consistency and standardization across journals, along with improved training for both authors and reviewers ([Budiyo et al., 2023](#)). These institutional changes support individual efforts to create more effective abstracts that serve as strong first impressions rather than barriers to reader engagement.

Evidence

(Goyal et al., 2022)

Writing Manuscript Better - Part II (Title, Abstract, Keywords, References, and Miscellaneous)

"a good abstract should be clear and complete. It should be concise in form, yet comprehensive in the information it covers. It often requires continual revision and editing. It is a good practice to ask a colleague who has not read the full manuscript, to read the abstract and give feedback on its completeness and comprehensibility."

(English, 2019)

Towards Article Acceptance: Avoiding Common Pitfalls in Submissions to Mathematical Thinking and Learning

"Writing abstracts is not a simple matter and can take considerably longer than anticipated. Abstracts should convey within 150-250 words (depending on the journal) the study's purpose, methodology, key findings, and conclusions or implications. As Saracho (2013) emphasises, an abstract should provide a "complete but concise description of the study" as well as incorporate key words that can be used for indexing and data bases (p. 48). The advice of Bol and Hacker (2014) is worth citing here: A poorly written

abstract creates a poor first impression that could set a negative tone for the remainder of the manuscript. Do not lose your audience in the first few words. One sure way to do this is to write an abstract that omits important details of one or more components of your research so that there is no easy way for the reader to judge your research as worth reading. (p. 41)"

"it is essential that it be written in a way that clearly communicates key details about the study. In a revision, it would be useful to clearly state 1-2 key findings, 1-2 central assertions about how/why the findings happened, and 1-2 conclusions or implications about what these findings mean for scholarship and for practice."

(Sulistiyo et al., 2021)

[Writing for International Journals: Lessons Learned from the Experts](#)

"in writing the abstract normally consists of background, objective, methods, settings, design, results and conclusion. It consists of 200-250 words. However, different journals have different formats."

(William, 2024)

[Unveiling the Art of Crafting an Insightful Abstract in Social Science Research: A Comprehensive Guide](#)

"Researchers can effectively communicate the essence of their studies by summarizing complex research, balancing brevity and clarity, selecting relevant information, avoiding technical jargon, and identifying key takeaways. Adhering to formatting guidelines, avoiding ambiguity, and revising and condensing abstracts enhance their quality."

(Budiyono et al., 2023)

[A QUALITATIVE EVIDENCE SYNTHESIS OF ARTICLE ABSTRACT WRITING IN ELT AND LITERATURE JOURNALS](#)

"several key recommendations for improving abstract writing in ELT and Literature journals are proposed, including greater consistency and standardization across journals, and improved training for authors and reviewers"